

1X Blues

Agent 001 has a hard time finding the single X

The Digit test centre was perplexed. The decision to send out DVDs to some corporate partners had run into rough weather. The problem was something like this: The DVDs had to be 1X-compatible. The DVD supplier had guaranteed 1X writing, however, the disks themselves were not branded, neither was there 1X written on them. Nevertheless, they tried to record the stuff, and the results were disastrous. This set off the alarm bells: they needed 1X-compatible DVDs, guaranteed. Hmm, this was a job for Agent 001.

When I got off the train suitably disguised as a marketing guy, it was afternoon. Lamington Road was bustling with activity as usual. "Hmm," thought I, "nice little shop selling CDs, DVDs and cigarettes. Perfect place to begin my investigation."

With a suitably professional voice I ask, "You have DVD-Rs? I need 1X-compatible ones."

"Of course," the guy says. "How many pieces?"

He sounds too ready to sell. "Are they branded?", I ask. "Yes, of course, they're Samsung," I am told.

"What's the price?," I ask. "Rs 120 each," he says, as he turns to the man next to me. "But how do you know what speed I want to write at?," I question.

No answer. I repeat the question. He looks at me and paints '4X' in the air with his finger. I tell him the problem my clients face. You can write stuff onto the DVD, he says. That's all.

Next stop, Video Plaza. Swank shop. I step in and the extremely well-dressed salesman comes up to me—later I discover he has a Nokia 6600, evidently not a salesman—and asks me what I want. I get to the point straightaway. He tells me that all DVDs are 1X to 4X compatible, and prices range from 90 to 135. I tell him the problem. He looks a bit fazed, though completely in control. He goes through the covers musingly and brings out a Pioneer DVD-R, smartly packaged, the cover proudly declaring '1X-4X compatible.' "This is Pioneer; it guarantees 1X to 4X

write speeds." How much does it cost, I ask. "Rs 375," he says, and adds, "Guaranteed 1X to 4X."

Expensive, I think, but as long as it

old customers. Familiar sight—lots of shops use this ploy to convince unsuspecting customers of their credibility. I get to the point straightaway. Predictably, the man at the counter nods, "How many do you want?"

"500 to 1000 pieces," I say, feeling as sleuth-like as ever. "But they have to be guaranteed 1X."

A voice behind me says, "Yes, may I help you?" I turn around and see a guy who looks like one who runs the shop. "I'm looking for 1X DVDs." He smiles. "Everyone wants 4X and you want 1X!" I nod and say, "You have to guarantee it."

He nods. I ask again, "How will you guarantee it?" half hoping he would tell me—high hopes.

"Please come into my cabin," he says, and I follow him in. "How many pieces do you want?"

"That's negotiable. Do you have a sample?"

He picks up the phone and dials a number. "Hello Ashish bhai, you didn't send me the sample of those 1X DVDs...yes I know...1X to 4X?...but the customer specifically wants 1X...you guarantee it?...what is the pack size?...50...branded...you say? It has to be 1X, what did you say the name was?"

Finally he tells me, "You'll get it, Rs 37 per piece. Guaranteed 1X. The DVDs are branded. How many do you want?"

"What brand name?"

"Thin Media."

"Just tell me how you determine it's 1X."

"It will be written on the DVD."

"What if it doesn't work?"

"Then come back to me, I will change the whole lot." He's sounding rather cranky by now.

Out on the street with his phone number in my pocket, I sum it all up in my mind as I walk back towards the station. It is not possible to ascertain whether DVDs will be guaranteed 1X-compatible. However, if required, there are ways to get them, though not at your average roadside shop. 



works...I guess! "But do you know it'll really work at 1X?"

"Everyone wants 4X DVDs. Well, you can take this other stuff, it's not branded, but it should work. It's Rs 35 apiece." He fishes out a box from the display. It's evident this is the same stuff that was being offered to me in the cigarette shop for Rs 120.

Outside, I go into a couple more shops: the same thing, the same names and prices, however, no guarantees of recording speed. I decide to take a last shot. In a side-alley I come across this shop proclaiming availability of all things musical. Up a short flight of stairs, I enter the shop with three or four shady-looking people around. Two of them behave like